

COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING, UIC

CS 377 Ethical Issues in Computing (3 Credit Hours)

“Evil comes from a failure to think” —Hannah Arendt

Fall 2026

Instructor & Course Details

Course: CS 377, Section TBD — Ethical Issues in Computing (3 credit hours)

Term: Fall 2026

Class meetings: Mondays and Wednesdays, TBD (see the schedule below for dates)

Classroom: CDRLC 2411

Method of instruction: In-person. Class time is built around short framing talks, table discussions, and small-group exercises rather than lecture; readings and materials are distributed through Canvas and the course website, and most written work is done on paper in class.

Instructor: Jack Bandy (he/him), jxb@uic.edu. You may call me Dr. Bandy or Jack, whichever you prefer.

Office: CDRLC 3454

Office phone: TBD

Drop-in (office) hours: TBD — days, times, and location will be posted in Canvas during the first week, and will include at least one slot outside of standard business hours. You are welcome to drop in without an appointment.

Teaching assistants: TBD — names, emails, and drop-in hours will be posted in Canvas.

Email: jxb@uic.edu. I generally reply within 24 hours on weekdays, and I generally do not check email on Saturday and Sunday. See “Email Expectations” below.

Course site: doethics.fun

Details and updates about class meetings, office hours, teaching assistants, assignment due dates, and grades will be regularly updated in **Canvas**.

Course Site

Canvas Course (canvas.uic.edu) - Students are expected to log in to Canvas regularly to learn about any developments related to the course, upload assignments, monitor grades, etc.

Public Website (doethics.fun) - As of this semester, the course now has a public site with reference materials for such as slides, assignment descriptions, ethical dilemmas, and more. The site is new and there are still improvements to be made, so you are encouraged to submit fixes/improvements in the [Github repository](#).

Course Information

Catalog Course Description

[CS 377. Ethical Issues in Computing. 3 hours.](#)

Official catalog course description: Communication skills for computing professionals, including presentation organization, visual aids, delivery techniques, and argument support. Ethical and societal issues in computing include privacy, intellectual property and ownership, and crime.

Prerequisite: Credit or concurrent registration in CS 251.

Further information: [UIC Computer Science course catalog](#).

Dr. Bandy's Course Description

What does it mean for Computer Scientists to be socially responsible? Billions of people interact with computational systems every day for communication, amusement, work, and more. Although many interactions appear to happen seamlessly, even the most mundane human-computer interaction often has ethical implications related to privacy, climate, power, inequality, public health, and more. To explore these ethical implications, this course will survey classical perspectives of ethics (i.e. Deontological Ethics, Utilitarian Ethics, Virtue Ethics, Care Ethics) and practice using them to interpret real-world situations involving humans and computers. Students will engage with a range of scholarship related to ethical issues in algorithmic decision-making, data management, user interface design, software engineering, search engines, algorithmic media feeds, large language models, and chatbots, to name some examples. Class sessions will promote active engagement through peer teaching, small group discussions, and more.

Learning Priorities

You are probably used to seeing concrete and specific “learning outcomes” for your math and CS classes. The outcomes for this class are more nebulous.

Namely, learning ethics is an ongoing practice. This class will therefore encourage you to continue discovering and practicing your own values and your own personal ethical commitments. In your other math and CS classes, you may eventually reach full expertise in a topic area, such as binary arithmetic. But you will not know everything there is to know about ethics just by completing this course.

Still, by the end of the course, you should be able to:

- analyze events and ethical dilemmas through the four lenses discussed in class: virtue ethics, deontological ethics, utilitarian ethics, and care ethics;
- identify and describe recurring ethical challenges in the design and use of computing systems;
- explain fundamental professional responsibilities related to ethical, legal, security, and social issues in computing;
- communicate ethical analyses clearly to different audiences, in writing and in a spoken presentation with visual aids;
- trace an ethical issue in a computing system back to specific design and engineering decisions, and propose alternatives;
- read a full-length book on a computing ethics topic and teach its central argument to your peers; and

- articulate and defend your own emerging ethical commitments as a computing professional.

Course requirement status: CS 377 is [required](#) for a BS in Computer Science at UIC.

Potential topics: Beyond the classical ethical theories (Virtue, Deontological, Utilitarian, and Care Ethics), the course draws on a rotating set of topics, including:

Value-sensitive / culturally-sensitive design	Labor displacement and deskilling
Privacy as contextual integrity	Ethics through speculative fiction and sci-fi
Addiction and “dark patterns” in UI design	Methods for measuring fairness and bias
Economic bubbles and hype cycles in tech	Online safety and content moderation
Bias, discrimination in large language models	Digital rights (to repair, to be forgotten, etc.)
Ethics and emotion in data visualization	Microtargeting and behavioral manipulation
Environmental costs of computing	Facial recognition (privacy and discrimination)
Anonymity and security for data analytics	Monopoly power / the politics of “big tech”
Inequality and the “digital divide”	Algorithmic feeds and their implications
Technology’s role in peace, conflict, and war	Intellectual property, licensing, open-sourcing
Dilemmas in cybersecurity	Medical/health technologies

Learning Materials

Readings and other materials will be provided through Canvas, printed copies, web archives, and/or linked PDFs.

There is no required textbook, however, the course draws heavily from *Computing and Technology Ethics: Engaging through Science Fiction* by Emanuelle Burton, Judy Goldsmith, Nicholas Mattei, Cory Siler, and Sara-Jo Swiatek.

Students will occasionally make their own selections of different research papers, news articles, case studies, books, and other materials to present and/or discuss in class.

If obtaining any course material presents a financial challenge, please tell me — there is nearly always a free path (library reserve, an open-access version, or a copy from me), and I would much rather arrange one than have you go without.

Respect for Copyright

I try to build this course out of open materials (public domain, Creative Commons, open-access preprints, and things I wrote myself), and where I can, I link them publicly on [doethics.fun](#).

Some materials are not open, and those are distributed only through Canvas. Please protect the integrity of that material: do not upload course materials you did not create to third-party websites, and do not share them with people who are not enrolled in the course. This includes worksheets, rubrics, and any readings posted behind the Canvas login.

Work you create for this course belongs to you. If I would like to reuse something you made — as an example for a future class, or on the course website — I will ask you first, and “no” is a complete answer with no effect on your grade.

Growth Mindset

Once again, unlike many other courses in the Computer Science department, the questions and problems discussed in this class often lack verifiable, complete, computable solutions. In many cases, there is no correct answer (nor even a general consensus!) to resolve ethical challenges.

For this reason as well as others, you may find course materials and exercises to be uniquely challenging. However, they are crucial to your personal growth and development. They are intended to help your intellectual development, not to trick you or discourage you. There may be times when you need extra help or extra time to process materials in order to reach your own understanding, which is quite normal.

Any student can succeed if they attend class consistently, participate in discussions, complete exercises, thoughtfully engage with feedback (including feedback from the instructor, TAs, and peers), and contact the instructor when struggling. These habits will help you develop a thorough understanding of the course material and ultimately succeed in the course.

If we are indeed successful, by the end of the course, you will develop an understanding of your own values and the ethical reasoning behind them. This is useful not only for the course, the CS degree, and your future career, but also for your life in general.

Tips for Success

Concretely, students who do well in this class tend to:

- do the reading before class, and write the pre-class reflection while the reading is still fresh
- bring a question to class, even (especially) a question they think is obvious
- say the half-formed version of the idea out loud instead of waiting until it is polished
- take notes by hand, and review them once within a day or two of class
- start the book project early rather than treating it as an end-of-semester problem
- come to drop-in hours at least once, before anything has gone wrong
- tell me early when something is going sideways, rather than after a deadline has passed

None of these require you to already be good at ethics. They mostly require showing up and being willing to think in public.

Technology Outside the Classroom

Students will need access to a web browser in order to use Canvas and access materials through the course website. This can be on your own laptop or a campus computer.

Exercises will be submitted and graded in Canvas unless otherwise noted.

Technology in the Classroom

TLDR: no phones, no laptops in class - take notes on paper!

I remember the frustration and shock I felt when I showed up to my first Computer Science course in college and learned that I was not allowed to use my computer. I have slowly realized that this policy was best for me as a student, and in most cases, it remains the best policy for an effective learning environment.

In Summer 2026, I looked at peer-reviewed scientific evidence on the subject of in-class technology usage. As with other times I have explored the evidence, my impression was that **in-class device**

usage is detrimental for learning, even when students feel accustomed to multitasking. Individual studies as well as meta-reviews continue to characterize devices in class as fundamentally distracting, with a negative influence on various measures of learning and performance.

Interestingly, while some students can multitask and still comprehend material *during* class time, those students experience significantly reduced *long-term retention* (Glass & Kang, 2019).

For these reasons and others, **by default, all class periods will be free from cell phones, laptops, and tablets**. In some cases we will use devices for activities, usually for a few minutes at the end of class.

This policy is intended for your own benefit as well as the benefit of your classmates, as using a device often has a chain reaction of distracting other students around you.

You will be provided a notebook and/or paper for the course to take notes and write down questions that arise or factoids you wish to research after class. You are always encouraged to ask about factoids that you might otherwise look up on your device - someone in the class might know the answer, or at least have some insight!

Also, if you prefer to take notes on a device that can sit flat on the table, and you are confident that you can do this without distracting yourself and without distracting others, please come see me to make an arrangement.

Finally, **I will revisit the no-phone no-laptop policy with students throughout the semester**, and I remain open to revising the policy based on feedback, student needs, and of course, peer-reviewed evidence.

In case you are curious, here is some of the evidence I looked at during Summer 2026 regarding in-class device distractions:

- Flanigan, Brady, Dai, & Ray (2023). Managing student digital distraction in the college classroom: A self-determination theory perspective. *Educational Psychology Review*. doi.org/10.1007/s10648-023-09780-y
 - “...research has suggested that these digital distractions can negatively impact learning and performance.”
- Dontre (2021). The influence of technology on academic distraction: A review. *Human Behavior and Emerging Technologies*. doi.org/10.1002/hbe2.229
 - “The detrimental effects of student smartphone and social media use on academic distraction are more conspicuous, especially with the pervasiveness of personal digital devices.”
- Martin, Long, Haywood, & Xie (2025). Digital distractions in education: A systematic review of research on causes, consequences and prevention strategies. *Educational Technology Research and Development*. doi.org/10.1007/s11423-025-10550-6
 - “Consequences for digital distraction included personal performance issues (66.67%), ineffective classroom instruction (23.33%), and problematic technology use (10%).”
- Wang, Tigelaar, Zhou, & Admiraal (2023). The effects of mobile technology usage on cognitive, affective, and behavioural learning outcomes in primary and secondary education: A systematic review with meta-analysis. *Journal of Computer Assisted Learning*. doi.org/10.1111/jcal.12759
 - Notably, this review found that *structured, instructor-directed* technology use can help: “using mobile technology produced medium positive and statistically significant effects on primary and secondary students’ learning.”
- Sana, Weston, & Cepeda (2013). Laptop multitasking hinders classroom learning for both users and nearby peers. *Computers & Education*. doi.org/10.1016/j.compedu.2012.10.003

- “...multitasking on a laptop poses a significant distraction to both users and fellow students and can be detrimental to comprehension of lecture content.”

Course Policies & Classroom Expectations

Assessment

This class aims to use principles of student-centered teaching, also referred to as “non-directive teaching,” which de-emphasizes quantitative grading. This teaching style focuses on open-ended dialogue, project-based learning, and student curiosity, rather than regurgitation and examinations. Still, in order to provide a final letter grade at the end of the class, I will use the following combination of graded exercises:

Category	Weight
Out-of-class exercises	20%
<i>Food in your feed</i>	
<i>Online account biopsy</i>	
<i>Online account scrap doll</i>	
<i>Speculative fiction</i>	
<i>Fairness definition</i>	
<i>Personal ethical commitment</i>	
“Read a Book” project	20%
<i>Book selection and justification</i>	
<i>2-page book report or un-essay</i>	
<i>Peer instruction / book presentation</i>	
<i>Actually reading the book</i>	
In-class group exercises	20%
<i>Expect about one per week</i>	
Pre-class reflections	20%
<i>Expect about one per week</i>	
Attendance, participation, and civility	20%

Further details and rubrics for each exercise will be published on Canvas.

Final grades use the following scale: A = 90–100%, B = 80–89%, C = 70–79%, D = 60–69%, and F = below 60%.

You can expect the following correspondence between your percentage grade in the course and your final letter grade, and the “equivalent” description from the registrar.

F	D	C	B	A
59% or below	60–69%	70–79%	80–89%	90–100%
Failure	Poor but passing	Average	Good	Excellent

Student Accountability for Coursework

Detailed instructions and a rubric for every exercise are posted on Canvas, usually at least one week before the work is due. If an exercise is still being developed, its Canvas page will say so, and I will announce it in class once it is ready.

Unless an exercise says otherwise:

- Out-of-class exercises and pre-class reflections are submitted in Canvas by the posted due date.
- In-class group exercises are completed and turned in on paper during class, which is part of why attendance matters.
- “Read a Book” milestones (selection, report, presentation) each have their own due date, spread across the semester so the project does not pile up at the end.

Expect feedback within about one week of the due date. See “Feedback, Revisions, and Regrading” below for how revisions and regrade requests work.

Midterm Grades

Midterm grades are not required for 300-level courses, so I do not file one with the registrar. Instead, grades in Canvas are kept current throughout the semester, so you can check where you stand at any point.

Around the midpoint of the semester I will also do a check-in: if your grade or attendance suggests you are at risk of not passing, I will email you directly so we have time to do something about it. You are always welcome to come to drop-in hours and ask me to walk through your standing with you.

Tests and Final Exams

There will be no tests or examinations in this class. I agree with Carl Rogers¹ that life itself offers enough examinations, and I hope that what you learn in this class will help you meet life’s tests with more confidence and satisfaction. See above for details regarding your final grade.

There is no final exam in this course, and nothing will be scheduled during the university’s final examination period. The last graded work is due during the regular semester; check Canvas for the exact date.

Attendance and Participation

Showing up makes a substantial difference in this course (and in life). For this class in particular, meetings are designed around table discussions and group work, so students are expected to attend, arrive on time, and participate.

Please notify the instructor as soon as possible when illness, personal emergencies, university obligations, religious observances, or other circumstances may prevent attendance. This is a courtesy to the community, as unexpected absences and late arrivals can be disruptive.

I take attendance each class. Three absences may be taken without penalty, and they do not have to be explicitly excused. If a student misses more than three classes without notifying the instructor, the instructor will reach out to them, and reserves the right to lower the “Attendance, Participation, and Civility” portion of the overall grade.

¹*On Becoming a Person*, Chapter 14

Generally, if you miss a fourth class without notifying the instructor, your “Attendance, Participation, and Civility” grade will be lowered from 20/20 to 18/20. These deductions will be noted in Canvas.

Students who miss more than half of all class sessions will not be able to pass the course. I hope we will not have to get into the specific counts - again, I will reach out if your attendance becomes an issue.

Attendance-related accommodations: If you have a Letter of Accommodation from the Disability Resource Center that includes accommodations around attendance, those accommodations take precedence over the attendance and late work policies described here. Please share your LOA with me and we will work out how the accommodations apply to this course.

Student-athletes: UIC has an [official missed class time policy](#) under which student-athletes provide formal documentation for class time missed due to NCAA or institutionally sanctioned events. Student Athlete Academic Services (SAAS) will provide you with that documentation; please bring it to me as early as you can so we can plan around it.

Late Work

Due dates will be listed in Canvas, and there is an automatic “sliding scale” that will deduct points based on how late you submitted the work, down to 50%.

Anything submitted more than one week after the original due date will only receive 50% credit.

If you anticipate any difficulty meeting a due date, contact the instructor as soon as possible.

Feedback, Revisions, and Regrading

We aim to return feedback on each exercise within about one week of its due date, give or take.

Opportunities to revise an exercise are specific to that exercise, as is the process for requesting a regrade. Both will be described in the instructions and rubric for the exercise on Canvas. If you believe an exercise was graded in error, contact the instructor as soon as possible (I prefer to avoid end-of-semester panic sessions).

Academic Integrity

Students are expected to follow UIC’s [Community Standards](#) and policies on [academic integrity](#).

Although I try to use open materials (i.e. public domain, Creative Commons, etc.), please help protect copyright integrity when appropriate, namely for materials distributed through Canvas.

In line with UIC’s mission to provide “an environment in which research, learning, and scholarship can flourish and in which all endeavors are guided by academic and professional integrity,” **the work you turn in for this class must be your own work.**

This is to ensure that **you** develop skills and knowledge from this course that will be valuable to you in your future courses, your career, and other areas of your life.

This does not mean that you need to complete all work in a bunker. Rather, you are encouraged to discuss your ideas with friends and classmates, and to explore related work (i.e. academic papers, blogs, video essays, forums, etc.). An important part of scholarship is standing on the shoulders of

giants,² (after all, we are in the City of the Big Shoulders³) and acknowledging whose shoulders we stand upon.

In other words, **always cite your sources!**

Please ask the instructor if you need clarity about academic integrity for specific exercises. When in doubt, it is always better to check.

I will reach out to you personally before submitting a report of academic misconduct.

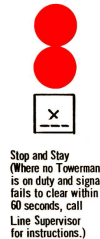
Use of Generative AI

Of particular interest as of August 2026 is the use of LLM-based tools and their implications for academic integrity. I am intentionally setting up many exercises this semester to be in-class, on-paper, in-person, etc., to reduce the possibility of using such tools for class exercises.

For the exercises where the question does come up, this course uses **CTA rail signal aspects** rather than the usual red-yellow-green traffic light. A traffic light has one lamp and one meaning. A rail signal stacks two lamps and tells you about the block you are in *and* the block ahead, which is much closer to the actual judgment call: not only “may I use this tool here,” but “what does using it here do to my ability to do the next thing.” The aspects below are from the 1973 CTA rulebook.

Every exercise on Canvas states its signal in the rubric. If a rubric does not name one, assume double red and ask me.

Double red — “stop and stay”



Two red lamps stacked vertically. CTA rulebook: “Stop and stay.”

No use of AI/LLM-based tools. This is the default for this course, and it covers all in-class work, all pre-class reflections, and the “read the book” portion of the book project.

Some things have to be fully learned and absorbed before you reach for a tool that will do them for you. Ethical reasoning is one of them: the point of the exercise is the thinking you do while you are stuck, and outsourcing that leaves you with an answer you cannot defend. You also need a foundational understanding of a domain before you have the discernment to judge whether a tool’s output is any good.

²Ironically, while this phrase is often attributed to Isaac Newton in a letter from 1676, it was first recorded in John of Salisbury’s book *Metalogicon* from 1159. I learned this from a blog post on BookBrowse.com

³Sandburg, Carl. “Chicago.” *Poetry* (March 1914).

Yellow over red — “proceed with caution, prepared to stop”

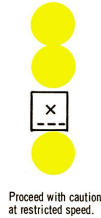


A yellow lamp above a red lamp. CTA rulebook: “Proceed with caution on main route, prepared to stop at next signal.”

Limited, optional, specific use, with citation. Certain exercises name a narrow set of tasks where an LLM is permitted but not required — for example, generating counterarguments to a position you have already written out, or checking a draft for clarity.

The named task is the only permitted use. Take this as a marshmallow test: notice where the tool fails, notice whether you actually found it useful, and pay close attention.

Double yellow — “proceed at restricted speed”



Two yellow lamps stacked vertically. CTA rulebook: “Proceed with caution at restricted speed.”

You choose where the tools fit, with citation. A small number of later exercises hand the judgment call to you.

This phase matters because it is the default in the world you are about to enter — eventually you always choose your own adventure. It seems worth having some practice with that open-ended judgment in a room full of people who will talk it through with you, before you have to make it alone. Every use is still at reduced speed and full attention, and you should be prepared to justify it.

Citing your use

Whenever the signal is yellow-over-red or double yellow, add a short note at the end of your submission:

I used [tool and version] to [what you asked it to do]. My prompt was: [prompt, or a summary if it was long]. Here is what I did with the output: [what you kept, changed, or threw away].

An honest citation is never penalized. Using a tool where the signal did not permit it, or using one without citing it, is a violation of the academic integrity policy above, and I will reach out to you personally before filing anything.

This policy is my current best judgment, not a settled matter, and it will keep evolving. I am genuinely interested in evidence-based arguments that I have it wrong — bring them to class.

Visitors

This class may welcome visitors (i.e. prospective students, guest speakers, etc.) during the semester. When possible, students will be notified in advance of guest attendance.

Privacy Note on Recording in Class

As of right now I do not plan to record class sessions this semester. If this changes, I will ask for your permission to record, and it will most likely be only audio.

This is especially important in a discussion-based class: recording can discourage open conversation, particularly around sensitive content, and much of what we do together depends on that openness. Similarly, please do not record any video or audio from class without permission.

FERPA

Federal law (the [Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act](#)) prohibits me from disclosing or discussing your grades over email. Please come see me during office hours if you want to talk about your work. I will work with TAs to try to keep grades updated in Canvas, so you can see how you are performing in class.

Email Expectations

Students are responsible for all messages sent to UIC email and Canvas accounts. I generally aim to respond to emails within 24 hours during weekdays. I generally do not check my email on Saturday and Sunday.

Approximate Course Schedule

The detailed and most current schedule will be published on the “[do ethics](#)” website. We may revise readings, activities, or due dates as course needs develop. Any changes will be announced in class and updated in Canvas.

University deadlines for adding, dropping, and withdrawing from courses are listed on the [UIC Academic Calendar](#).

Week	Topic(s) / In-Class Activities	Readings / Work Due
1	Warm-up: Conocimiento; Introduction to Virtue Ethics	
2	Introduction to Deontological Ethics; Introduction to Utilitarian Ethics	
3	Labor Day holiday. No classes. ; Introduction to Care Ethics	
4	Review theories of ethics; Ethics in Algorithmic Feeds	
5	Algorithmic Feeds and Content Moderation, Continued; Intro to Privacy; Preview short story (“Here and Now”); Privacy, Continued	
6	Privacy, Continued; Discuss short story (“Here and Now”); Preview short story (“Message in a Bottle”); Inequality and Justice; Discuss short story (“Message in a Bottle”); Preview short story (“Codename Delphi”)	
7	Asynchronous class. Dr. Bandy away; Inequality and Justice, Continued; Faces and Fairness; Computing and War; Discuss short story (“Codename Delphi”); Preview short story (“If an Algorithm Can Cast a Shadow”)	
8	Medical and health technologies; Intro to CyberSecurity; Intro to Ethical Challenges from LLMs; Discuss Speculative Fiction Exercise	
9	Ethical Challenges from LLMs, Continued; Discuss short story (“If an Algorithm Can Cast a Shadow”); Intellectual property	
10	Intellectual property; “Hooks” and “Nudges” in Design; Presentation Tips	
11	Book Presentations; Overview of Fairness Definitions Exercise	
12	Book Presentations	
13	Book Presentations	
14	Book Presentations; Student Wellness Day. No classes.	
15	Synthesis and conclusions	

Another Disclaimer

This syllabus is intended to give the student guidance on what may be covered during the semester and will be followed as closely as possible. However, again, we might decide to alter this syllabus as course needs arise, and I will communicate such changes through in-class announcements and in

writing via Canvas and/or email.

Accommodations

Disability Accommodation Procedures

UIC is committed to full inclusion and participation of people with disabilities. Students who face or anticipate disability-related barriers should contact the [Disability Resource Center](#) at drc@uic.edu or (312) 413-2183 to create a plan for reasonable accommodations.

To receive accommodations, you will need to disclose the disability to the DRC, complete an interactive registration process with the DRC, and provide me with a Letter of Accommodation (LOA). Letters of Accommodation can be presented at any point in the semester and, unless otherwise noted, do not expire once obtained. Upon receipt of an LOA, I will gladly work with you and the DRC to implement approved accommodations.

Religious Accommodations

I will make every effort to avoid requiring that work be submitted on [religious holidays](#). Students seeking religious accommodations should notify the instructor by the tenth day of the semester, or at least five days in advance when the observance occurs earlier. Please email me with the subject heading “YOUR NAME: Requesting Religious Accommodation” and the date(s) you will be absent. You do not need to supply any verification of your attendance at religious services.

I will make every reasonable effort to honor your request and not penalize you for missing class. If an assignment is due during your absence, you will be given an assignment equivalent to the one completed by students in attendance. Students may appeal through [campus grievance procedures](#) for religious accommodations.

Classroom Environment

Classroom Community

The mission statement at my elementary school⁴ was “to provide a safe learning environment where every child can reach full potential and bring about positive change in our world.” Lofty as it is, I find it to be a meaningful statement that aligns with UIC’s official mission statement: “to provide the broadest access to the highest levels of educational, research, and clinical excellence.”

You can help UIC work toward this mission by contributing to a respectful, welcoming, and inclusive environment for every member of our class. If aspects of this course result in barriers to your inclusion, engagement, accurate assessment, or achievement, please notify me as soon as possible.

Assume goodwill, listen carefully, debate ideas rather than people, respect privacy, and remain open to revising your position.

⁴This was Wilmore Elementary School in Jessamine County, Kentucky. Our principal Andrea McNeal wrote the mission statement.

Feedback on the Course

In my view, being an effective educator is a life-long journey, meaning I still have a lot to learn in order to do my job effectively. There will be structured opportunities for feedback throughout the course, but please do reach out directly with any additional feedback, questions, ideas, and/or suggestions about how the course might be improved.

Preferred Names and Pronouns

If your name or pronouns do not match the class roster, please let the class know so that we can address you the way you want to be addressed. I use he/him pronouns. For more information, see: <https://www.mypronouns.org/what-and-why>.

Community Agreement

The list below is a starting point, not a finished rulebook. During the first week we will go through it together, and I will ask you to suggest additions — practices you want from me, from the TAs, and from each other. We will take a straw vote on the final version, post it in Canvas, and revisit it during the semester.

The version we agree on governs how we treat each other in this room. If something in it stops working, say so and we will change it.

Guidelines for Participation and Classroom Conduct

Active participation is one of the most important ways you will learn in this course. I am very aware that participation looks a little different for everyone, and will evaluate your participation accordingly. Still, in general, an engaged student will:

- come to class prepared, for example, by having completed pre-class reflections
- contribute regularly to class activities and discussions
- stay on-task during class
- listen attentively to peers (no side conversations or unnecessary disruptions)
- have an open mind and seek to understand (not judge and make assumptions)
- be gracious and open to change in their ideas, arguments, and positions
- assume goodwill in all interactions, even in disagreement
- complete their work in a timely manner
- reach out to the instructor if they start to fall behind

Content Notices

This is a 300-level University course; as such, we will aim to discuss topics with maturity, dignity, humanity, rigor, and respect for scholarly inquiry.

Some course materials address war, discrimination, surveillance, sex, violence, and related subjects which may be distressing. Please know that the goal is never to cause distress, but to meaningfully engage with real-world issues.

Our classroom provides a space for civil exchange of ideas, which intentionally includes a variety of perspectives and positions. Some readings and other content may expose you to ideas, subjects, or views that may challenge you, cause you discomfort, or recall past negative experiences or traumas. I try to include content notices whenever appropriate. If you have suggested changes (i.e. if there

is a place where you recommend adding a content notice), or you would like me to be aware of a specific topic of concern, please email or visit me during office hours.

Resources: Academic Success, Wellness, and Safety

Student Wellbeing

As a student at UIC, I hope you have come to enjoy the learning process and the life of the mind, and I hope you enjoy this particular course. I also understand that life as a college student can sometimes become distressing and overwhelming, which can make it difficult to engage in class.

So, to help you succeed in this course (and in life), I encourage you to proactively care for your body and mind. If you are struggling or anticipate any trouble attending class or turning in assignments on time, **please let me know as early as possible** and I will do whatever I can to help you prioritize your wellbeing.

Below are some of the many support services and resources available to all UIC students:

- [Current Student Resources](#) – a one-stop shop for links to resources in the following categories: General, Academic, Student Support, Student Life, Technology, Health and Safety, and Getting Around Campus
- [UIC Tutoring Resources](#)
- UIC College of Engineering Tutoring Program (link TBD — ask your Engineering advisor, or see me)
- Academic success programming for first-generation students (link TBD)
- Programs and initiatives supporting the UIC undergraduate experience and academic programs through the [Student Success Initiative](#)
- If you are experiencing personal hardships (e.g. personal and family emergencies, academics, interpersonal conflicts, personal safety, physical and mental health concerns, food or housing insecurity) and need resources and assistance, please reach out to the [Student Assistance](#) division, supported by UIC's Office of the Dean of Students
- [Student Guide for Information Technology](#) – a comprehensive resource for UIC students describing the most commonly used IT services and tools supporting your success
- [Navigating Health Resources at UIC](#) – explore the many resources that are on campus to support students' health and wellbeing and learn about how you can access them.

Importantly, **if you are in immediate distress**, please know the UIC Counseling Center provides high-quality crisis intervention services, available 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. You can walk into the Counseling Center during business hours to request to talk to a crisis counselor, or you can call the Counseling Center main line at (312) 996-3490. If you are calling outside of business hours, select “2” during the automated greeting to be connected to a crisis counselor. You can find additional mental health resources and services on the Counseling Center Website and the Student's Guide to Accessing Behavioral Health Services at UIC.

For immediate crisis support outside of UIC, call or text “9-8-8” any time, 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. Dialing 988 will connect you to a trained crisis professional. 988 offers services in Spanish, American Sign Language, and over 240 languages through tele-interpretation services. The 988 website has an online chat feature, too.

We all need the help and the support of our UIC community. Please visit my office hours for course

consultation and other academic or research topics. For additional assistance, please contact your assigned college advisor and visit the support services available to all UIC students.

Academic Success

- Equity and Inclusion in Engineering Program (link TBD — ask your Engineering advisor, or see me)
- **UIC Library** – locations on east and west campus, with research support in person or online via chat. Stop by the reference desk in the IDEA Commons at Daley Library, make an appointment for research help, or consult the subject-specific [Research Guides](#).
- **Academic Center for Excellence (ACE)** – individualized help with reading, writing, study skills, and time management. Call (312) 413-0031.
- [Academic advising](#) and the offices supporting the UIC undergraduate experience and academic programs

Wellness

- **U&I Care Program** – assistance for students facing personal hardships, including emergency funds and referrals
- **UIC Counseling Center** – free, confidential intake with a trained therapist for students who pay the student health services fee, leading to brief individual or group therapy, psychiatry referrals, or care coordination with a community provider. Located in the Student Services Building; call (312) 996-3490 during business hours. (See above for 24/7 crisis intervention.)
- **Campus Advocacy Network** – confidential victim services and advocacy under Title IX, which gives you the right to an education free from gender-based violence and discrimination, including sexual assault, domestic violence, harassment, and stalking. Call 312-413-8206. To make a report to UIC's Title IX office, email TitleIX@uic.edu or call (312) 996-8670.

Safety

- **UIC SAFE App** ([link to download](#)) – a free personal security tool that puts you in easy contact with dispatchers and first responders in an emergency
- [UIC Safety Resources](#) and the [UIC Police](#) – safety tips, alerts, and campus security programs
- **Walking Safety Escort and Night Ride** – use either if you are uncomfortable traveling anywhere on campus. You are discouraged from staying in university buildings alone, including lab rooms, after hours.
- **Emergency response guides** – from the Office of Preparedness and Response. Please review the recommendations for various emergency situations.
- Emergency: Dial 5-5555 from a campus phone, or (312) 355-5555 from a cell phone

Support for Parenting Students

Balancing school, childcare, and work can be difficult, and I would rather know about it than not. If you are a parenting student, please tell me early so we can plan around it. Occasionally bringing a child to class to cover an unexpected gap in care is perfectly acceptable — sit near the door so you can step out if you need to. Non-parenting classmates, please leave the seats near the door available for this.

UIC supports parenting students by providing affordable, high-quality childcare for infants, toddlers,

and young children, along with a comprehensive wraparound care system, study-play areas across campus, accessible lactation rooms, year-round family events, and more. For more information, contact Melinda Young (mmcghe2@uic.edu) or visit the [Little Sparks website](#).

Tutoring and Academic Support Centers

The blurbs in this subsection are mostly boilerplate from the syllabus template published by UIC's Center for the Advancement of Teaching Excellence (CATE).

The Writing Center offers friendly and supportive tutors who can help you with reading and writing in any of your courses, not just English. Tutors are ready to help with other writing as well, such as job applications, personal statements, and resumes. The tutor and you will work together to decide how to improve your writing. If you have not started your assignment, that is OK. A tutor can help you brainstorm or make an outline. Tutors understand that you might be using the Writing Center for the first time. They are ready to guide you through your first session. You can choose to work with a tutor in person or in real time over the internet using video, audio, or chat and a whiteboard. For more information and to schedule an appointment, visit the [Writing Center website](#).

The Math and Science Learning Center, located in the Science and Engineering South Building (SES) at 845 W. Taylor St. 3rd Floor, Room 247, is a meeting place for students in Math, Biological Sciences, Chemistry, Earth and Environmental Sciences, and Physics. At the MSLC, students can meet with graduate teaching assistants for tutoring in 100-level courses, attend informal group study sessions with other students, or meet up with friends to attend one of the workshops, seminars, or other activities sponsored by the MSLC during the semester. Visit the [MSLC website](#), call 312-355-4900, or email at mslc@uic.edu.

The Academic Center for Excellence (ACE) can help if you feel you need more individualized instruction in reading and/or writing, study skills, time management, etc. Please call (312) 413-0031 or visit the [Academic Center for Excellence \(ACE\)](#) website for more information.

Health Services

Student Health Services are available if you get sick during the semester. The Family Medicine Center is committed to providing high-quality, student centered care and services. It has attending physicians, residents, and nurse practitioners on staff to provide the full range of primary health care services. The Family Medicine Center also offers a limited set of health services at no additional cost to students who pay the Student Health Service Fee (SHSF). Services include caring for an acute or urgent illness (e.g., cold, strep throat, asthma attack, flu) or an injury. More information can be found on the Family Medicine Center's Student Health webpage.

A Closing Note

Lastly, here is a picture of Hannah Arendt. She said that “evil comes from a failure to think.” If we are successful in this class, we will do some real thinking, and perhaps prevent some evil.



Hannah Arendt, photographed on New Year's Day, 1944. © Fred Stein/dpa/Corbis

Parts of this syllabus are based on the syllabus template from UIC's Center for the Advancement of Teaching Excellence (CATE), available at <https://teaching.uic.edu/cate-teaching-guides/syllabus-course-design/syllabus/>.